The Lighthouse at Saltmere Point

A short story in five chapters (fiction)

Chapter 1: The Keeper of Saltmere Point

Saltmere Point is a thin finger of black rock that reaches out into the grey sea, three miles beyond the fishing village of Brindle Cove. At its very end stands a white lighthouse with a red lantern room, and for thirty-one years it had been looked after by one man: Elias Marrow.

Elias was sixty-eight years old, tall and slow, with a white beard that the wind liked to tangle. Every morning he climbed the one hundred and twelve spiral steps to the lantern room, checked the lamp, polished the glass, and wrote the weather in a thick green logbook. Every evening he climbed them again to switch the light on.

In the lamp room, on a small shelf beside the window, sat a brass ship's clock. It had a round white face and a tiny crack across the glass. The clock had not moved in nine years. Its hands were stuck at seventeen minutes past three, and Elias had never once tried to repair it.

The people of Brindle Cove knew about the clock, though nobody spoke of it. The baker, Mrs. Tallow, who sent fresh loaves out to the lighthouse every Friday, would only say that some clocks are better left alone. Elias would nod, thank her for the bread, and change the subject to the tides.

He lived simply. He had a kettle, a narrow bed, a radio that picked up two stations, and a window that looked toward the mainland. He was not unhappy. He was, as he liked to say, exactly as busy as a lighthouse needs a man to be.

Chapter 2: A Visitor on the Supply Boat

On the first Tuesday of November the supply boat Gannet bumped against the little stone jetty. Its captain, a cheerful man named Tobias Reed, handed over a crate of tinned food, two cans of lamp oil, and an unexpected passenger: a twelve-year-old girl with a red backpack and a very serious expression.

"This is Nora," said Tobias. "Your granddaughter. Her mother has to work on the mainland this month, and she wrote to you. Did the letter not arrive?" Elias searched his coat pockets and found the letter, still sealed, behind a packet of tea. He looked at Nora, and Nora looked back, and neither of them said anything for a moment.

Nora turned out to be a girl who asked questions. How did the lens turn? Why was the lamp red on one side? How many ships passed in a week? Elias answered patiently, and by the second evening she had learned every step of the staircase and could recite the lighthouse's signal: two long flashes, then one short, every fifteen seconds.

On the third day she noticed the clock. "Why does it say three seventeen?" she asked. "It has said that since before I could read," said Elias. "My grandmother Ines," said Nora slowly. "Mum told me about her. She used to light the lamp with you." Elias said that was true. He did not say anything else, and Nora, who was clever, did not ask again that day.

That night the radio warned of a strong storm moving in from the north-west. The forecaster used the word "severe" three times. Elias turned the radio off, checked the shutters twice, and went up to light the lamp an hour earlier than usual.

Chapter 3: The Night the Lamp Failed

The storm arrived at nine o'clock in the evening. The wind howled around the tower, the rain hit the windows sideways, and the waves broke over the rocks with a sound like falling furniture. In the lantern room the great lens turned steadily, throwing its two long flashes and one short across the black water.

At twenty minutes past eleven there was a loud bang below them, and every electric light in the tower went out. The generator in the cellar had flooded. The lens stopped turning. For the first time in thirty-one years, the light at Saltmere Point went dark.

"There is a fishing boat out there," said Nora, who had been watching the sea with the binoculars. "I saw its lights an hour ago. It was heading for the Three Sisters." The Three Sisters were the three jagged rocks just south of the point, and every sailor in the district knew to stay far away from them.

Elias did not hesitate. In a cupboard under the stairs sat the old oil lamp that had lit the tower before electricity came, wrapped in a blanket and polished every spring in case it was ever needed. He carried it up the one hundred and twelve steps, with Nora behind him carrying the lamp oil, and together they filled it, trimmed the wick, and lit it.

The lens could still be turned by hand with a heavy brass crank. Elias took the first turn, and Nora took the second. They counted the pattern aloud, two long and one short, over and over, while the storm tried to tear the roof off the world.

Chapter 4: The Halcyon Dawn

The boat out in the dark was the Halcyon Dawn, a small fishing trawler with a crew of four. Her captain, Anca Dobre, had lost her radio an hour earlier when a wave swept over the deck. She could see nothing but black water, white foam, and the faint shape of rocks she could not name.

"Light!" shouted her young deckhand, Matei, pointing into the distance. Two long flashes, then one short. Captain Dobre knew that pattern. She knew it from twenty years of fishing out of Brindle Cove. It was the signal of Saltmere Point, and it told her exactly which way the rocks lay.

She turned the wheel hard to the east, away from the Three Sisters, and the Halcyon Dawn crawled through the waves toward the safe water on the far side of the point. Behind her the rocks roared. Ahead the little yellow light kept flashing, steady as a heartbeat.

In the lantern room, Elias and Nora took turns at the crank for six hours. Their arms ached and their hands blistered. Nora fell asleep sitting up twice, and each time Elias turned the lens alone until she woke. Neither of them stopped the pattern even once.

At ten minutes to six the sky in the east turned the colour of weak tea. The wind dropped. The trawler, battered but whole, slid into the shelter of Brindle Cove's harbour, and all four of her crew stepped onto the dock alive.

Chapter 5: Three Seventeen

By morning the whole village knew what had happened. Mrs. Tallow arrived at the jetty with two dozen warm rolls and a basket of apples. Captain Dobre came in a borrowed rowing boat, climbed the one hundred and twelve steps with her hat in her hands, and shook Elias's hand for a very long time.

The village council met that afternoon. For years there had been talk of closing the lighthouse and replacing it with a cheap automatic beacon on a metal pole. By the end of the meeting, the council voted unanimously to keep the tower, repair the generator, and pay for a trained keeper to work beside Elias.

While the grown-ups talked, Nora went up to the lantern room alone. She looked at the brass clock for a long while. Then she picked it up, turned the little key at the back, and wound it gently. Something inside it clicked. The second hand shivered, hesitated, and began to move.

Elias found her there. He stood in the doorway and said nothing. "I'm sorry," said Nora. "I should have asked." Elias walked across the room, set the clock on the shelf, and looked at it for a moment. Then he smiled, and it was the first time Nora had seen him smile with his eyes.

"Ines would have wound it herself years ago," he said. "She never could stand a stopped clock." He did not move the hands. The clock kept running from three seventeen onward, and every afternoon at exactly that time, Elias made a pot of tea for two. Nora came back every summer after that, and the tea was always hot when she reached the top of the stairs.